

Chapter 71 Part 4

The nursing home's fees were at the average level for Hazhou City, but because most of the staff here were those once-abandoned children, they took care of the residents very attentively and could get along well with the elderly.

Currently, there were over 120 people living in the nursing home. They had established a unified cafeteria, bathhouse, activity center, and dormitories, and even offered classes for the elderly.

Because Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were more interested in Angel Orphanage, and Gu Zhaoyuan also wanted them to understand more about establishing the orphanage, he talked at length about many amusing incidents from the orphanage days.

A group of children abandoned by their parents had formed new families. They treated each other as brothers and sisters, living together every day. Occasionally they would envy the children who were adopted, but many children who were adopted would run back because they missed the orphanage.

Gu Zhaoyuan had always felt this work was meaningful and worth doing.

When he expressed this view, Liang Shi suddenly asked: "Then why did your father suddenly stop doing it?"

Gu Zhaoyuan's smile suddenly froze on his face, then turned into a bitter smile. He shook his head helplessly and said: "Can I say that I don't know either?"

Liang Shi was puzzled: "When your father wanted to convert it into a nursing home, you should have already been helping him. How could you..."

"My father kept some things from us when he did them." Gu Zhaoyuan explained earnestly: "Many of the children who left Angel Orphanage, especially those adopted by wealthy families—their records would be erased from the orphanage. When my father handled this part, he never let us get involved because we couldn't really help. Moreover..."

He paused, "My father suddenly became ill after being traumatized."

"May I politely ask what year your father fell ill?" Liang Shi asked.

Gu Zhaoyuan suddenly became guarded. "Why are you asking these things?"

Liang Shi hadn't intended to hide anything. She vaguely revealed her purpose for coming: "We have a friend who came out of Angel Orphanage and now wants to look into this friend's past."

"Who?" Gu Zhaoyuan asked.

Liang Shi shook her head: "I'm sorry, I can't say, but we suspect your father's illness might be related to her."

Xu Qingzhu had asked Lin Luoxi, so she knew that Angel Orphanage was converted into Ci'ai Nursing Home ten years ago.

That was the third year after Qi Jiao's jumping incident.

Liang Shi was only speculating. She said this to Gu Zhaoyuan just to find a more reasonable excuse.

Sure enough, as soon as she said this, Gu Zhaoyuan immediately responded: "My father's illness? I also don't know what traumatized him to become like this now. You actually know?"

"Just speculation." Liang Shi said: "Many things happened to our friend, and the timing is very close to when your father fell seriously ill."

She spoke ambiguously, yet it made Gu Zhaoyuan fall into contemplation.

Liang Shi sighed softly. "Could you take us to meet your father?"

Gu Zhaoyuan slowly shook his head. "I'm sorry, my father's consciousness isn't very clear now. He often speaks nonsense. It's better not to meet him."

"Then do you still have the group photos from the orphanage?" Liang Shi said: "I heard from my friend that you took group photos every year with all the children in them."

"Yes, we do." Gu Zhaoyuan answered.

This wasn't a difficult request to fulfill, so Gu Zhaoyuan led them to his office.

His office was very simple—just a desk, two chairs, and a bookshelf with various types of books on it.

When they entered, there was a little boy wiping the windows.

The boy's foot was somewhat lame, but he worked very earnestly.

Gu Zhaoyuan told him to return to the dormitory to rest, and the boy limped out.

Liang Shi kept watching his foot, her heart quietly filling with sympathy. At the same time, she gained a deeper understanding of what Director Gu was doing. The old Director Gu, who had persisted in charitable work all this time, was truly admirable.

She suddenly wanted to do something for these causes too.

She was so lost in thought that she didn't hear Gu Zhaoyuan calling her. It was only when Xu Qingzhu touched her arm that she came back to her senses and said softly: "I'm sorry."

"It's fine." Gu Zhaoyuan handed her the photo album.

This photo album wasn't like ordinary albums. Although each photo had a year and date on it, and the background was always Angel Orphanage, every single photo showed signs of being cut.

Some had many people cut out, some fewer—it was purely a matter of luck.

Liang Shi asked: "Were all the cut-out ones adopted by wealthy families?"

"Not necessarily." Gu Zhaoyuan said: "Some adopting families had requirements, and we would meet their requests."

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu looked through the album together, examining each photo carefully, but they didn't find anyone resembling Qi Jiao.

If there was one, it had probably been cut out.

Gu Zhaoyuan said his father fell seriously ill the year before Angel Orphanage was changed to Ci'ai Nursing Home.

After the illness, once he regained some consciousness, he established Ci'ai Nursing Home.

Not long after that, his mental state became somewhat abnormal.

Liang Shi frowned. It seemed they hadn't found many clues here either.

The previous director had done everything seamlessly. Unless they could ask him directly, but now Gu Zhaoyuan wouldn't give them the opportunity to meet the old director.

Having found no clues, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu didn't propose leaving. Instead, they wandered around the nursing home.

The activity center in the back was very lively. A group of elderly people gathered together—some playing poker, some playing badminton, and others sitting together chatting while knitting sweaters.

There were all kinds of people. The staff members responsible for looking after them were all children who had once been at Angel Orphanage.

Facing this work of interacting with the elderly, they didn't feel annoyed at all. Rather, their faces showed genuinely satisfied smiles. Some elderly people would pull them over and chat with them at length.

The missing familial affection seemed to be fulfilled in an instant.

It was as if they were the real family.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu even had dinner at the nursing home cafeteria. They followed behind Gu Zhaoyuan, and along the way, many people greeted him.

It was clear that Gu Zhaoyuan was very popular here.

Footnotes:

None needed for this section.